

# Homonyms, homophones, and homographs

SOME WORDS HAVE THE SAME PRONUNCIATION OR SPELLING BUT MEAN DIFFERENT THINGS.

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Variations in pronunciation or spelling are what distinguish homonyms, homophones, and homographs. Using the correct word is important for both spoken and written English.

## Homonyms

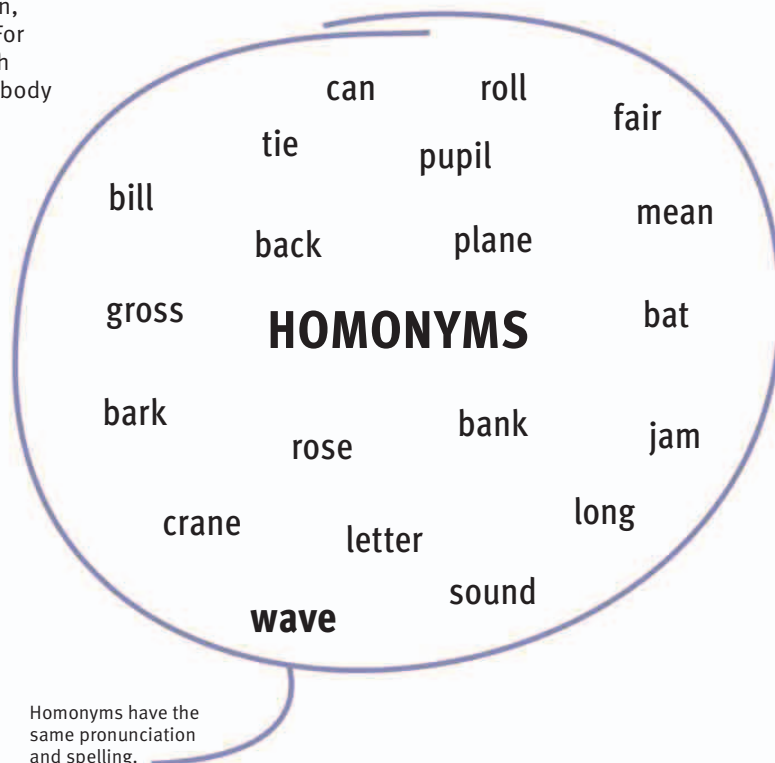
Words with the same spelling and pronunciation, but different meanings, are called homonyms. For example, the word *fair* can refer to an event with games and rides or to the idea of treating somebody in a reasonable way.

The word **homonym** come from the Greek **homos**, which means “same,” and **onyma**, which means “name.”

## REAL WORLD

### Crossword puzzles

Crossword puzzles can be difficult without a good understanding of homonyms, homophones, and homographs. The clues in cryptic crosswords take advantage of the confusion caused by these words in order to mislead the reader.



### ▷ Wave

The homonym wave has several meanings. These include the kind of wave caused by ocean currents, as well as the movement of a hand as a greeting gesture or signal.

